



**Familiar role:** Harendra Singh succeeded Janneke Schopman as the coach of the Indian women's hockey team earlier this year. Harendra had served at the same position in the past before being appointed as the United States men's team coach in 2021.

GETTY IMAGES

Although the team played an exhibition game last month for the turf inauguration, this will be his first official return.

Make no mistake, there will be the pressure of defending the title in front of an expectant home crowd. But much has changed over the past year, including the performances of other teams.

China, for one, proved its Asian Games win was no fluke, claiming a historic maiden silver at the Paris Olympics earlier this year.

While it enters as a continental champion, it comes with added confidence as an Olympic medallist. Although this time it will be a different and young team, with four debutants and head coach Alyson Annan is not expected to be on the bench.

Japan, another Asian team competing in Paris at India's expense, will arrive with temporary staff, a limited roster of experienced players and no coach Jude Menezes. Korea, meanwhile, brings an experienced lineup, aiming to return to its winning ways. Malaysia and Thailand complete the lineup.

**With a curtailed Hockey India League following the ACT and the Pro League, the Indian team hopes to use this as a stepping stone toward its future goals.**

With the Asia Cup in 2025, the World Cup, and the Asian Games in 2026, a successful ACT would mark the first step towards regaining confidence ahead of a busy season. But, as 2023 showed, a good start is only half the battle.



**Women's ACT:** November 11-20, 2024

**The teams:** India, China, Malaysia, Japan, Korea, Thailand.

**Indian squad:** Savita, Bichu Devi, Uditia, Jyoti, Vaishnavi Phalke, Sushila Chanu, Ishika Chaudhary, Neha, Salima Tete, Sharmila Devi, Manisha Chauhan, Sunelita Toppo, Lalremsiami, Navneet Kaur, Preeti Dubey, Sangita Kumari, Deepika, Beauty Dungdung.